

Student Safeguarding Policy 2026

NavGurukul Foundation For Social Welfare runs residential campuses for individuals aged 14 to 30, supporting pathways to careers in technology, business, and design. This policy exists because the people who come to us often carry the weight of systems that have failed them before. We take that seriously. Every student on every campus has the right to be safe, to be heard, and to be protected — not just in policy, but in practice.

This policy applies to everyone associated with NavGurukul: employees, interns, fellows, volunteers, NGO partners, resource individuals, and visitors. It is reviewed every six months and must be signed by all who join.

This policy is equivalent to a Child Protection Policy and incorporates all required components under Indian law, including compliance with the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012. Sexual harassment complaints are handled under the separate POSH Policy, which operates in parallel.

Our Philosophy

We recognise and respect the dignity of every individual regardless of age, culture, religion, beliefs, disability, physical or mental health, colour, ethnicity, race, caste, national origin, gender, sexual orientation, language, economic status, or any other factor. Safeguarding at NavGurukul is not a compliance checkbox — it is a core expression of who we are.

Who This Policy Covers

Students are any person enrolled in and living on a NavGurukul residential campus.

Members of NavGurukul are all employees (full-time and part-time), interns, consultants, fellows, and volunteers.

Vendors are any individuals or organisations providing services to NavGurukul, including manpower and service providers.

A **child** is any person under 18 years of age. A **student** may be a child or an adult — this policy applies to all students regardless of age, with additional legal obligations triggered for those under 18.

Scope of Safeguarding

NavGurukul recognises six categories of harm that this policy is designed to prevent and respond to:

Physical Abuse — Any intentional act causing physical harm: hitting, shaking, throwing, or using physical contact to punish. Includes giving students alcohol, drugs, or harmful substances.

Emotional Abuse — Persistent acts that harm a student's sense of worth or safety: conveying worthlessness, imposing unrealistic expectations, withholding affection, intimidation, threats, public humiliation, or bullying.

Sexual Abuse — Forcing or enticing a student to take part in sexual activities, whether or not the student is aware. Includes penetrative and non-penetrative acts, sharing pornographic material, and encouraging sexually inappropriate behaviour. Disclosure by the student is the single most important indicator.

Neglect — Persistent failure to meet a student's basic physical or psychological needs — including failing to ensure safety, leaving students unsupervised, or failing to respond to allegations of harm.

Peer-to-Peer Abuse — Harm caused by one student to another, including physical harm, sexual harassment, sexual violence, coercion, and sexting.

Bullying and Cyberbullying — Repeated behaviour intended to hurt someone — name-calling, threats, exclusion, spreading rumours, or online harassment via social networks or messaging platforms.

Standards of Behaviour

What All Members of NavGurukul Must Do

- Create an environment that supports students' personal, physical, social, emotional, and intellectual development

- Respect and actively encourage students' voices and perspectives
- Be inclusive — no exclusion on the basis of age, gender, caste, religion, disability, ethnicity, sexual orientation, or any other factor
- Hold one-on-one meetings with students only in public spaces or in rooms with the door open
- Use only official NavGurukul email addresses for communication with students
- Intervene and report to the SSO immediately upon any suspicion or evidence of harm
- Cooperate fully with any safeguarding investigation

What All Members of NavGurukul Must Never Do

- Inflict any form of physical, verbal, emotional, or sexual abuse on a student
 - Give students alcohol, drugs, or any harmful substances
 - Communicate with students via personal messaging apps or social media outside of official work channels
 - Use abusive language in the presence of students
 - Photograph or record students without consent from both the student and NavGurukul management
 - Store photos of students on personal devices without explicit consent
 - Discriminate on the basis of race, caste, gender, religion, disability, sexuality, or any other status
 - Develop a romantic or sexual relationship with a student
 - Touch a student inappropriately or in a culturally insensitive way
 - Suggest or imply any inappropriate behaviour or relationship
 - Stand aside when witnessing inappropriate behaviour by one student toward another
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The Student Safeguarding Response Team (SSRT)

NavGurukul has constituted a Student Safeguarding Response Team (SSRT) to oversee the implementation of this policy and respond to all safeguarding concerns across campuses.

Composition

Role	Name
Student Safeguarding Officer (SSO)	Priyanka Dangwal / Bilqees Jan

POCSO Nodal Officer	Mubin
People & Culture	Aayushi, Ashwini
Alumni Representative	Shweta Sharma

Campus Scrum Leaders

Campus	Scrum Leader
Raigarh	Pooja Palkandwar
Eternal University	Meenakshi Dilip Parihar
Jashpur	Sakshi
Dantewada	Sheikh Mazhar
Kishanganj	● Vacant — interim managed by central SSRT
Sarjapura	● Vacant — interim managed by central SSRT
Dharamshala	● Vacant — interim managed by central SSRT

For campuses with vacant positions, a named interim contact must be communicated to students and staff on campus. No campus should operate for more than three months without a designated on-ground safeguarding contact. P&C will prioritise filling these roles.

Responsibilities of the Student Safeguarding Officer (SSO)

The SSO is the primary student-facing safeguarding lead. They are the first point of contact for any safeguarding concern and are responsible for the welfare of the student through the entire process.

- Receive and document all safeguarding disclosures and complaints
- Forward incident reports to all SSRT members immediately upon receipt
- Convene and lead SSRT meetings within two days of a complaint being received
- Ensure the student is supported and protected throughout — including access to counselling and medical support
- Inform the individual against whom an allegation is made within one day, and manage their presence on campus through the investigation
- Maintain the centralised Student Safeguarding Incident Report in a confidential file
- Lead student sensitisation sessions at the start of every cohort and every six months

- Communicate the policy to the community every six months
- Coordinate with the POCSO Nodal Officer on any case involving a student under 18

Responsibilities of the POCSO Nodal Officer

The POCSO Nodal Officer is NavGurukul's designated compliance officer under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012. This is a mandatory legal designation.

- Report any case involving a student under 18 to the local police or Special Juvenile Police Unit (SJPU) within **24 hours** of the SSRT being informed — this is a legal obligation under Section 19 of the POCSO Act, not discretionary
- Maintain a record of all POCSO-related incidents, reports made to authorities, and follow-up actions
- Coordinate with the SSO and P&C team through any investigation involving a student under 18
- Ensure campus notice boards at all NavGurukul campuses display required POCSO information — Childline (1098), POCSO e-Box, and the Nodal Officer's own name and contact
- Lead or coordinate biannual POCSO sensitisation sessions for staff
- Liaise with the local District Child Protection Unit (DCPU) as needed
- Complete at least one POCSO awareness training within 60 days of appointment, and refresher training annually

Responsibilities of the SSRT

- Keep this policy current, reviewing it every six months
 - Ensure all NavGurukul members understand and follow the policy
 - Maintain a centralised record of all complaints and outcomes
 - Notify relevant authorities where required by law or by the nature of the complaint
 - Make decisions based on the five essential duties outlined in this policy
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When and How Complaints Come to Light

A safeguarding concern may come to light in several ways:

- A written or verbal disclosure from a student, alumnus, parent, or community member
- A staff member noticing a change in a student's behaviour or physical condition
- A third party raising a concern about someone associated with NavGurukul

- Monitoring of student welfare by campus staff

Types of Disclosure

Direct — A student tells you directly. Acknowledge calmly, find a private space, and listen without interrupting.

Indirect — A student hints without stating it directly (e.g., “I don’t like being alone with X”). Ask open-ended questions. Do not supply the words or lead the student.

Disguised — A student describes it as happening to a friend. Do not challenge this framing. Encourage them to keep talking and reassure them it is not their friend’s fault.

Reluctant — A student reveals something but asks you not to tell anyone. Do not make promises you cannot keep. Be honest: “I may need to speak to the SSO, but I will always tell you what I’m doing and why.”



Responding to a Disclosure

When a student discloses something to you, your role is to **listen and support** — not to investigate, judge, or solve.

Do:

- Stay calm. A strong reaction can cause the student to stop talking.
- Find a private, comfortable space.
- Use active listening — let the student speak in their own words and at their own pace.
- Reassure the student that they have done nothing wrong and that it is brave to speak up.
- Tell them clearly what will happen next: “I’ll need to speak to the safeguarding officer. They know how to help.”
- Write down what was said as soon as possible, in the student’s own words. Sign and date it.

Do not:

- Press for details or ask “why” questions.
- Promise to keep anything secret.
- Ask leading or suggestive questions.
- Make judgements about whether the student is telling the truth.
- Investigate the situation yourself.

- Speak negatively about the person the complaint is against.
 - Make the student feel singled out or different.
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Handling Complaints: The SSRT Process

Once a concern is reported to the SSO or any SSRT member:

1. The SSO forwards the incident report to all SSRT members immediately.
2. An SSRT meeting is convened within **two days** to assess: immediate risk; urgent protective actions; preservation of evidence; whether external reporting is required; safeguarding procedures to follow; communication with the wider community if needed.
3. The student is protected and supported throughout — including access to counseling and medical support as needed.
4. The individual against whom the allegation is made is informed within one day, told the nature of the concern, and offered support. They are not encouraged to resign. The investigation continues regardless.
5. Where the individual continues to be present at NavGurukul during the investigation, a written risk management plan is put in place — including no contact with the student who made the complaint.
6. All witnesses are asked to submit written statements.
7. A Student Safeguarding Incident Report is created and maintained in a confidential file accessible only to the SSO and SSRT.

For students under 18: The POCSO Nodal Officer must report to the local police or SJPU within **24 hours** of the SSRT being informed. This is a mandatory legal obligation under Section 19 of the POCSO Act, 2012. Failure to report is a criminal offence under Section 21.

Five Duties That Guide Every Decision

- **Right to Safety** — The student's best interests are the primary consideration in every decision.
- **Right to Privacy** — The rights of both the student and the person the complaint is against are protected throughout.
- **Right to Information** — Relevant external agencies and partners are informed of immediate actions where appropriate.
- **Right to Integrity** — The process is conducted with honesty, fairness, and sensitivity.

- **Right to Report** — Any member of NavGurukul who observes or suspects harm must report it to the SSO. There is no threshold of certainty required — suspicion is enough.
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Student Safety & Awareness

NavGurukul is committed to ensuring students know their rights, understand what safe and unsafe behaviour looks like, and know how to seek help without fear.

At the start of every cohort and at least once every six months, the SSRT will conduct:

- A **personal safety orientation** covering body autonomy, good touch/bad touch, the right to say no, and what constitutes inappropriate behaviour
- **Age-appropriate sessions** on recognising harm, peer safety, online safety, and healthy boundaries — delivered in the student's preferred language where possible
- A **campus induction** that clearly names the SSO, explains how to report, and affirms that reporting is safe and will not result in retaliation

Safe Recruitment

All employees, interns, fellows, volunteers, and contractors who have direct or regular contact with students must, before onboarding:

- Complete a **police verification / character certificate** check
- Sign a **self-declaration** confirming no criminal record related to offences against children
- Pass **reference checks** that explicitly assess suitability for working with young people

No individual has unsupervised access to students until verification is complete. P&C owns this process.

Mandatory Campus Displays

The following must be physically displayed on notice boards at every NavGurukul campus at all times, in the local language:

Item	Details
Childline	1098 — 24/7 emergency helpline for children in distress

POCSO e-Box	ncpcr.gov.in — online complaint portal for child sexual abuse
POCSO Nodal Officer	Name and contact number
Student Safeguarding Officer	Name and contact number
Local SJPU / Police Station	Name, address, and contact number

Campus Scrum Leaders are responsible for ensuring these displays are in place and current. The SSRT verifies at every six-month review.

Crisis Communications

Where details of a safeguarding incident become known to the wider community:

- Issue a holding statement affirming NavGurukul's commitment to student welfare and the process being followed
 - Invite community members to come forward if they have relevant information
 - Communicate clearly how concerns can be reported
 - Schedule counselling sessions — group and individual — for those affected
 - Reduce workload or allow time off for staff particularly affected by the incident
 - Update the community on developments only where appropriate and legally permissible
 - Do not make any public communication without consulting the SSO and SSRT
 - Remember: anything written may be used in legal proceedings
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Privacy and Record Keeping

All safeguarding records — incident reports, investigation documents, communications, and outcomes — are confidential. They are stored in a secure, centralised file accessible only to the SSO and SSRT.

Limited information may be shared with a campus to which a student is transferred, to ensure their continued protection.

All safeguarding records must be retained by P&C for a minimum of **two years** after the conclusion of any incident, regardless of outcome.

The identity of any student involved in a safeguarding incident must never be disclosed publicly or to the media, in line with Section 23 of the POCSO Act.



Consent and Sign-Off

My signature confirms that I have read this policy and agree to uphold its standards. I understand that any action inconsistent with this policy, or failure to take action mandated by it, may result in disciplinary consequences up to and including being asked to leave the organisation.

Name: ____

Designation: ____

Signature: _

Date:

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